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GUTS AND GLORY

Two months after Independence, the Indian military was engaged in the first of the many wars and conflicts it would fight to safeguard the country's national security. I have looked at battles that were won and contributed significantly to influencing the post-war geostrategic landscape and the shaping of India's frontiers. The emphasis on India's frontiers is essential, as most of the wars have been a result of disputed borders. Some notable omissions could strike readers. The 1962 war was not considered because the focus was on battles that India won. The Haji Pir battle of the 1965 war was a strong contender, but missed out as the territory gained was returned after the war.

Defence of Poonch

(1947-48 war)

After the capture of Uri, two battalions under Lt Col. (later promoted to Brigadier) Pritam Singh fought their way into Poonch town, which was surrounded by the raiders. For one year, supported by locals, they held out against all odds. The IAF played an invaluable role in establishing an air bridge, flying in supplies, guns and ammunition. Brigadier Pritam not only defended the town but also ensured that the civil population of approximately 45,000 was supported and fed. The strong bonds established between the army and the civilians during this period endure even today.

